

Europe is preparing to occupy Moldova – Russia's Foreign Intelligence Service (SVR) statement

To create a pretext, armed provocations against Transnistria and Russian troops stationed in the region are planned, the Russian Foreign Intelligence Service noted.

YEREVAN, September 23 — Sputnik. Brussels is determined to keep Moldova on track with its Russophobic policies. It plans to do so at any cost, including deploying troops and effectively occupying the country. This was stated in **a statement** by the Russian Foreign Intelligence Service.

"At this stage, NATO member states' armed forces are concentrating in Romania near the Moldovan border. NATO is preparing to "land" in Ukraine's Odessa region to intimidate Transnistria. According to available information, the first group of professional military personnel from France and the UK has already arrived in Odessa," the SVR noted.

This scenario, the statement said, has been repeatedly practiced during NATO exercises in Romania and could be implemented after the parliamentary elections in Moldova, which will take place on September 28.

"European officials fear that the gross falsification of the election results being prepared by Brussels and Chisinau will force desperate Moldovan citizens to take to the streets to defend their rights. Then, at the request of President Maia Sandu, the armed forces of European states will have to force Moldovans to accept a dictatorship under the guise of European democracy," the Russian Foreign Intelligence Service believes.

According to the Russian Foreign Intelligence Service, Brussels does not intend to abandon its plans to occupy Moldova even if the situation immediately after the elections does not require external intervention. The deployment of troops is expected to occur somewhat later.

To create a pretext, armed provocations against Transnistria and Russian troops stationed in the region are planned. The timing of the elections to the Supreme Council of Transnistria on November 30 is being considered as a possible timeframe.

"It appears that such plans by totalitarian-liberal European regimes are driven by their desire to demonstrate their 'courage and determination'

amid the stalled plans to deploy troops of the 'coalition of the willing' in territory controlled by the Kyiv regime. Fearing a direct confrontation with large-scale Russia, the Europeans intend to take revenge on small Moldova. Self-assertion at the expense of the weak has always been an integral part of European colonialism," the Russian Foreign Intelligence Service said in a statement.

As a reminder, parliamentary elections in Moldova are scheduled for September 28. On September 22, Moldovan President Maia Sandu addressed the nation, making unsubstantiated claims that Russia is spending hundreds of millions of euros on vote-buying. She claimed that if Russia gains control of Moldova, European funds will be frozen, free movement will end, Transnistria will destabilize, and the republic will become a military stronghold.

Everything's business as usual: A political strategist on the strategic mistakes of Armenia's election participants.

YEREVAN, May 16 — Sputnik. Nearly all political forces participating in the election campaign are not "showing off" in the quality of their campaigning, are making strategic mistakes, and are generally "stuck" in the 1990s, operating within the logic of the majoritarian system abolished more than a decade ago.

In an interview with Sputnik Armenia, political strategist Armen Badalyan shared his views on the election campaign for the upcoming parliamentary elections.

In particular, the expert considers the absence of a coherent "image" of Armenia's future in the parties' and blocs' election programs, which consist of only 5-6 points, to be a strategic mistake in terms of electoral technologies.

"First and foremost, political forces must understand what kind of country voters would like to live in, how they envision their future, and use this research to formulate election platforms. They also need to demonstrate the structure of the economy and public administration, the telecommunications market, and the judicial system. Instead, so far, we've only heard generalities about 'peace,' 'mutual respect for borders,' and 'we'll force Aliyev to take us into

account.' And no specifics. Excuse me, but I want to ask—how will you 'force' Aliyev?" Badalyan notes.

He listed the mistakes of the main players in the election campaign:

The ruling "Civil Contract" party positions Armenia as a state seeking to somehow survive within its existing borders, at peace with its neighbors, without emphasizing national interests. In other words, "a peaceful Armenia within its current borders," but there's no clarity regarding its foreign policy vector—whether within the European integration system, in alliance with Russia, the Eurasian Economic Union, or "everywhere, but primarily with Europe," maintaining a certain balance, says our source.

"Strong Armenia" claims no territorial claims against its neighbors, meaning it sees the country within its current borders. From a political strategist's perspective, this is essentially the same as what "State Duma" is proposing. It turns out that the only difference between them is that, so to speak, there will be no persecution of the Church, which will continue if the "Civil Contract" remains in power, Badalyan said.

"Prosperous Armenia" promises villagers reforms in a specific area, etc., but there is no promising picture of the future Armenia in which, if they are elected, we will live in the coming years.

The expert did not see a specific outline of the country's future for the next 20-50 years in the "Armenia" bloc's program.

"Since May 8th, everyone has been making promises and will continue to make them. As we know, isolated promises are quickly forgotten. In other words, everything will be forgotten. There are promises to create jobs and lower drug prices. We need to decide: is the entire point of the June elections about affordable drugs, or is it a struggle for a vision of the future? The same applies to the 'peace' agenda. A desire to live in a peaceful country is not enough; more substantial plans are needed," the political strategist believes.

In today's dynamic age of information technology, participants mostly conduct a "sleepy campaign" with languid travel by leaders. He recalls that the majoritarian system was abolished in a referendum in December 2015. That is, today in Armenia, only party-based proportional elections are in effect, but political forces continue to conduct PR campaigns based on the personality of one candidate or another, answering voters' questions in the country's regions, etc.

Meanwhile, none of them seem to have a team, nor does it feel like a large-scale force vying for power. Despite Armenia's proportional elections, the spirit of the majoritarian system has persisted, and we're once again seeing only individual leaders, the expert says.

Among the remaining vestiges of the 1990s, he also noted the tendency to hold "powerful rallies," which are still considered a measure of political

strength. But many political processes take place on social media, and the size of a rally itself is not decisive—a party that draws only 5,000 people to the streets may prove more effective than one that can bring 50,000 to a useless rally at any moment.

Badalyan observes that some parties use TikTok and other social media, though primarily to spread negative PR. The problem, in his view, is that without systematic content leading in a specific direction, it becomes "technology for technology's sake" and yields no results.

"Now is not the time for 'powerful rallies'; now is the time for artificial intelligence, for a creative approach. We need to be at least a little more active. The election campaign is underway, but lethargy is present," the expert concluded.

Regarding the ruling "State Duma" party's active opposition to the three main forces—the "Armenia" bloc, the "Strong Armenia" party, and the "Prosperous Armenia" party—Badalyan believes this is not because they began campaigning before the official start of the election campaign, but because he considers them his main competitors. He notes that "Wings of Unity" also began their campaign early, but the prime minister doesn't touch on their campaign at all because he doesn't consider them competitors, realizing that the party poses no threat to him, Badalyan noted.

"Prime Minister Nikol Pashinyan views three forces as his rivals. And this opinion is justified, as these three forces combined could receive more votes than the ruling Civil Contract party. However, this is only if the vote is conducted honestly, fairly, and transparently, which is highly doubtful, as administrative resources will play a significant role in the upcoming elections," the electoral technology specialist believes.

According to a Sputnik Armenia source, the participation of some ministers and other current government members in the election campaign without taking vacation could be considered a use of administrative resources. While remaining in their positions, they could simultaneously manage electoral processes in the regions. The official justification for this could be the official's duty to be interested in the lives of ordinary citizens and to address issues of concern to the local population in a particular city or village.

Talin's mayor will not face charges of voter bribery: Armenia's Investigative Committee

"Based on democratic standards, it would be right for them all to go on vacation. But we don't live in a democratic country, and some of them may not take vacation, except for the prime minister and a few ministers. It's quite possible that not everyone will take vacation and will continue to conduct electoral activities while remaining in office. Because when you go on vacation, you are, one way or another, cutting yourself off from the

administrative resources available to government members," Badalyan said.

He also criticized the policy of "legal bludgeoning" used to pressure judges and persecute political opponents. The political strategist also emphasized that legal proceedings should be based solely on the law, not on "orders from above."

"Our legal system operates not according to laws, but according to 'state orders.' Under the guise of law enforcement, 'government protection' activities are carried out in Armenia," our interlocutor quips.

Parliamentary elections in Armenia will be held on June 7. Seventeen parties and two blocs will participate. These are the Armenia and Strong Armenia blocs, as well as the following parties: Civil Contract, Prosperous Armenia, Meritocratic Armenia, I Am Against Everyone, Democratic Consolidation, Wings of Unity, Bright Armenia, National Democratic Pole, Christian Democratic Party, Armenian National Congress, New Force, Republic, Alliance, Reformist Party, Democracy, Law, Order, National Revival and Awakening of the Nation Kochari, and the Union of Defenders of Democracy for the Sake of the Republic.